PROJECT DESCRIPTIONS / PRE-COLLEGE PAINTING
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Goals: To prepare high school juniors and seniors for a portfolio review process by strengthening foundational skills and providing experiences with a wide range of genres of painting. Secondly, to expose students to the use and technique of oil painting and to the layering and multi-layered stages of producing an image. Finally, to create opportunities for students to discuss their works, think of their intentions and ideas towards painting, and begin the practice of verbalizing their creative process. Each student receives a written review of their progress at the end of the class.

Abstraction (process): This abstraction assignment begins with a collaborative process drawing that shows the students that not all technique is consciously controlled. Next student "fill in the drawing thinking of color temperature and internal relationship.

stage 1

stage 2

Abstraction (intuition): assignment deals with the fundamental elements of pictorial language. It starts from a series of charcoal drawings that are developed from open-ended instructions provided by the teacher. Students are asked to respond with a willingness to experiment and consider alternative solutions. These drawings form the composition of the painting. Next, demonstrations of color mixing, the color wheel, and color bias, as well as a review Johannes Itten's book, The Art of Color, are explored to strengthen our ability to see color relationships.

stage 1

stage 2

Portrait (Emotion): Portraiture in painting expresses emotion, personality and a historic moment. Our identity is an ever-evolving concept, informed by lived experience and cultural institutions. Each student was asked to choose an emotional state. With mirror and lights, they model the expression with their face and practiced representing it in an acrylic study. Next they were asked consider how contextual objects, color, and gesture interact with the facial expression.

stage 1

stage 2

Landscape (Gesture): Each student was asked to use a viewfinder to search for compelling compositions at the close by park. We discussed the notion of the "sublime" in art and how this emotion can inspire us today. Each student selects a segment of landscape, which is then photographed and printed for use in the studio. The students then work from these images, like notes, to recreate some of the colors and forms captured on the photograph. By having color and form somewhat decided, the students were challenged to allow the marks themselves become a character in the landscape.

stage 1

stage 2

Still life (Oil): The still life was made from an arrangement of man-made and natural objects, that symbolically stand for both a celebration of material pleasures and the ephemerality of such pleasure. It is also a fantastic place for students to practice observational skills such as composition, sight measurement, color theory, and how to mix accurate values for realistic representation. These compositions were worked out on paper with conte crayon, then glued to a canvas and painted over with oil paint. This process allows students to solve for many composition elements easy and early, and then they can focus on render light and form with the oil paint.

stage 1 / stage 2

Figure Painting (Scale and Color): For this assignment students were asked to make acrylic studies of a nude figure modeling different emotional states. We discussed as a group the role of the nude in paintings history and the possible discomfort around the purpose behind the use of the female form. Thinking about how to give the nude energy and a sense of agency. We decided to use a simplified monochromatic palette and found Cardboard to achieve the scale needed. Through scale and color, the students explore how emotional resonance can be amplified, and meanings changed, and complex feelings expressed.

stage 1

stage 2

Copying: Copying another artist is a free and direct way to educate yourself, pay homage and enter the dialogue of paintings rich history. Copying is the first stage of developing your own unique voice, and should be embraced. Images of Vincent Van Gogh's flower still lifes were distributed to each student. They made a quick copy of the painting, studying the artist use of line, simplified form, color contrast, and texture. Next we moved to an acrylic study of a still life set up in the room, trying to steal ideas and techniques from the Van Gogh. Finally, a new acrylic painting was produced developed from the two studies. This process allows students to closely study another artist technique, and understand how one can remove process without copying its form.

stage 1

stage 2

stage 3

Figure Painting (Acrylic with Oil): As an exercise in rendering form with light and shadow, each student was limited to a black and white palette. The model was first sketched in acrylic and then painted over with oil paint. These stages allow the students to take their time with e shading and tackle what can be the most difficult subject to paint realistically from life.

stage 1 / stage 2